

Identification

Medical specialties defined using the American Board of Medical Specialties (24 boards, 38 specialties) and the European Union of Medical Specialists (43 sections)



Guideline-issuing professional societies identified through guideline registries (ECRI, Guidelines International Network), PubMed (Practice Guideline type), society websites, and an audit of graded guidance in societies' own journals (June 2026). 84 candidate societies; 7 not obtained (paywalled or non-English only), yielding 77 included societies



Current guidelines of the 77 included societies retrieved (PubMed Central, publisher open access)



Guidelines screened against the prespecified eligibility criteria



Clinical practice guidelines included and extracted (n = 536; 77 professional societies, 24 specialties)



Graded recommendations extracted (n = 22,877); every evidence level mapped to the normalized scale (none unmapable)



Primary analysis — specialties with at least 5 guidelines and guidelines with at least 3 graded recommendations (n = 22,693 recommendations; 21 specialties; 75 societies)

Screening

Guidelines excluded:

- Superseded or duplicate edition (deduplicated to the most recent version)
- Graded by strength of recommendation only, with no level of evidence
- No per-recommendation evidence grading
- Not a clinical practice guideline (review, commentary, methods, or letter)

Included